

A daily scan of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear “so what for your school” line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, [get in touch](#).

TOP LINE

- A quieter 24-48 hours nationally, but Ofqual's third annual cyber security survey, published today, shows school cyber-attacks continuing to fall: 27% of secondaries hit by an incident in 2025/26, down from 34% two years ago, with recovery times also improving.
- Closer to home: Barnsley Council's cabinet meets on 7 October to approve a £4.4m increase (to £7.37m total) for the 40-place specialist primary school planned at The Mill, Worsbrough Bridge.

→ **For your school:** Worth flagging to SEND colleagues working with Barnsley families awaiting the new places.

DATES FOR THE DIARY

7 Oct 2026 — Barnsley Council cabinet considers the revised £7.37m budget for the Worsbrough Bridge specialist primary school.

16 Oct 2026 — Midday deadline for Sheffield secondary school applications for September 2027 entry.

22 Oct 2026 — NEU national executive reconvenes to decide whether to relaunch the paused strike ballot.

26-30 Oct 2026 — Sheffield schools' autumn half term.

■ CYBER-ATTACKS ON SCHOOLS KEEP FALLING

■ **Ofqual's latest poll shows fewer, less damaging cyber incidents.** The exam regulator's third annual Teacher Tapp survey, published today, found 27% of secondary schools and colleges were hit by a cyber incident in 2025/26, down from 29% the year before and 34% in 2023/24. Two-thirds of affected schools recovered immediately (up from 55%), and incidents causing critical damage fell to 7%. Ofqual still flags a responsibility gap: only 9% of staff say senior leadership owns cyber security, versus 46% pointing to IT teams. ([GOV.UK](#) / [Ofqual](#))

→ **For your school:** Worth a line in the next SLT update confirming who in your school actually owns the cyber-incident response plan.

■ SHEFFIELD/SOUTH YORKSHIRE: BARNSLEY'S SEND PLACE COST OVERRUN

■ **Cost of 40 new SEND places in Barnsley rises by £4.4m.** Barnsley Council's cabinet meets on 7 October to approve a revised £7.37m budget - up from the plans approved last October - to refurbish The Mill at Worsbrough Bridge into a 40-place specialist primary school. Survey and design work found more extensive access and equipment needs than expected; the scheme remains fully funded by a ring-fenced government capital grant, with Waterton Academy Trust as preferred delivery partner. ([The Star](#))

→ **For your school:** A reminder that SEND capital schemes regularly cost more than first budgeted - useful context if you're advising on local place-planning timelines.

JARGON-BUSTER · RING-FENCED GRANT

Comes up in the Barnsley SEND funding story above.

Government money that can legally only be spent on the purpose it was awarded for (e.g. new SEND places) - a council can't redirect it to plug other budget gaps, but equally can't flex it if costs rise, as Barnsley's are now doing.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. [Explore School+](#)

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; “Who’s Losing Learning?”
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Daily is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.